POLSC 343: American Foreign Policy

Exam 1 Review Sheet — Historical Background (Weeks 1–4)

Terms, concepts, themes, and events. The explanations are left to you — fill them in from your lecture notes and the readings.

This is a skeleton, not a summary. Every item below is something you should be able to explain in one or two sentences without looking it up. If you read an entry and cannot say what it is and why it matters, that is the gap to go fill.

Section 2 gives you the definitions worth memorizing word-for-word. Everything else is a prompt.

> The four questions the unit is built around: (1) What are the major periods in US foreign policy, and what divides each one? (2) What is continuous across periods, and what genuinely changes? (3) How do we reconcile US expansion and Cold War practice with American rhetoric about democracy, self-determination, and human rights? (4) How does historical memory of these periods shape policy debate today?

1. Periodization

Period	Dates	In a phrase
Early Years	1783–1870	Weak, small, continental. No alliances.
Transitional Period	1870–1945	Growth, overseas expansion, two world wars, unresolved fight over leadership.
Hegemonic Period	1945–2025	Preponderance of power. Alliances, bases, high spending, a built order.
Post-Hegemonic Period	2025–future	Open question.

2. Definitions to Know Cold

Term	Definition
Mercantilism	Doctrine holding that military power and economic influence complement each other; policies favor the mother country over its colonies and competitors.
Zero-sum game	One party's gain requires another party's loss.
Autarky	National economic self-sufficiency.
Hegemony	A preponderance of global power. Note: not the ability to get everything you want.
Deterrence	Discouraging an actor from taking an action by making the negative consequences clear. Requires credibility.
Threat that leaves something to chance	Schelling's term: a threat that is credible because events may escape anyone's control once set in motion.
Security dilemma	One state's efforts to make itself more secure make its neighbors less secure.
Containment	Long-term resistance to Soviet expansion. Kennan's version emphasized non-military means; NSC-68 militarized it.

Term	Definition
Liberal internationalism	The postwar order: US leadership with self-constraint, rules-based governance, multilateral cooperation. "Liberal" in the classical sense.
Burden sharing	Distribution of costs and responsibilities among allies.
Nullification	A state's claimed right to void federal law it deems unconstitutional.
Manifest Destiny	The claim that westward expansion was divinely mandated (O'Sullivan, 1845).
Unipolar moment	The post-Soviet period in which the US was the sole superpower.
MID	Militarized Interstate Dispute — a Correlates of War measure. Counts state-to-state disputes only.

3. Historical Background: The Early Years (1783–1870)

Baseline facts

- Territorially small. Few states in the international system. No alliances until the 20th century.
- Tiny military as a share of population. Low defense spending. Low trade through the 1970s.
- Founders wary of standing armies — see Brutus X and the Farewell Address.
- The Army's actual role through the 1800s. The "Indian Wars" in the campaign-duration record.
- What the MID data leave out, and which direction the error runs.
- Westward expansion as the organizing fact — and who else was competing for that territory.

Events, terms, and moments

- Treaty of Paris, September 3, 1783
- Postwar weakness: abandoned allies, French trade restrictions
- Strategic choke points — New Orleans, the Mississippi
- Mercantilism and zero-sum thinking; Smith and Ricardo
- Washington's Farewell Address — what it actually recommends
- Hamilton vs. Jefferson: two visions
- Jefferson and executive power: Barbary, the Louisiana Purchase
- Louisiana Purchase (1803): Napoleon, Haiti, Livingston, $15 million
- War of 1812 — and its relationship to the Napoleonic Wars
- Monroe Doctrine (1823) — content, and the enforcement problem
- Slave Trade Act 1807; US ban 1808; Abolition Act 1833
- British boarding of US-flagged ships; the Creole case (1841)
- Tariffs of 1828 and 1832; Nullification Crisis; Jackson; compromise tariff of 1833
- Revenue tariffs vs. protective tariffs — and why the line is blurry
- Aroostook War — a militarized dispute with no fighting
- Capture of Monterey (1842) — Catesby, communications, delegated authority
- Texas: Mexican independence 1821, American migration, Texas Revolution 1835–1836, annexation 1845
- Mexican–American War (1846–1848) — why the Southwest was attractive

- Manifest Destiny (O'Sullivan, 1845)
- Civil War — the North/South economic divide, and its roots in the founding
- Civil War's international dimension — the British calculation

4. Historical Background: Transition (1870–1945)

The turn outward

- US economy surpasses Britain, 1870s
- The Turner thesis and the closed frontier — what question does it pose?
- Ironclads and steam: how naval technology drives overseas basing
- Spanish–American War (1898): Cuba/Guantanamo, Puerto Rico, Philippines, Guam; Hawaii annexed
- The expansion debate — five arguments on each side, two of them on both
- Monitors vs. a blue-water navy
- Post–1898 spending: veterans' benefits, Navy, coaling and repair depots
- Roosevelt Corollary and Dollar Diplomacy: Nicaragua, Dominican Republic, Haiti

War, rejection, and the interwar years

- US entry into WWI (1917): neutrality, submarine warfare, the Lusitania
- Why "sparks" are not causes — Franz Ferdinand, the Lusitania, and the delays after each
- Consequences of WWI — be able to list them
- Treaty of Versailles; the League of Nations; two Senate rejections
- Wilson, the Irreconcilables, Henry Cabot Lodge, Henry Stimson, Elihu Root
- The sovereignty objection to multilateralism — and where it reappears later
- Washington Naval Conference (1922); London Naval Conference (1930)
- Engagement without commitment — why "isolationism" is the wrong word
- Great Depression: October 29, 1929; protectionism and autarky
- The 1936–1938 spending cut; when recovery actually began
- Hitler to power 1933; the 1936–1937 treaties; Austria and the Sudetenland, 1938
- Poland, September 3, 1939; fall of France; Battle of Britain
- Japan: Manchuria 1931, China, oil and rubber
- The 1930s as a new wave of imperialism — Germany, Italy, Japan
- Neutrality Acts 1935–1939 → Cash and Carry → Destroyers for Bases → Lend-Lease
- Pearl Harbor, December 7, 1941; the Philippines, December 8

5. The Cold War and US Hegemony

From world war to cold war

- Roosevelt dies April 12, 1945; Truman and the Manhattan Project; Germany surrenders May 8
- The bomb: invasion, demonstration, or use — and the Soviet motive
- Henry Stimson: targets, Kyoto, and sharing technology with the USSR
- Hiroshima August 6; Nagasaki August 9; surrender August 14, 1945

Sources of the divide

- Pre-1945 mistrust: 1917 intervention in Russia, the second front, Molotov–Ribbentrop, the Warsaw Uprising
- Soviet demand for secure borders
- Percentages Agreement (1944)
- Occupied Germany and the occupation zones
- Britain withdraws support from Greece and Turkey, 1946
- Soviet pressure on Iran and Turkey; the Security Council, 1946

The architecture

Figure	Document or policy
Harry S. Truman	Truman Doctrine, March 1947
George C. Marshall	Marshall Plan / European Recovery Program, June 1947
George F. Kennan	Long Telegram (1946); X Article, "The Sources of Soviet Conduct" (1947)
Paul Nitze	NSC-68 (1950)

- Kennan vs. Nitze — the disagreement, and why Kennan opposed NATO
- What Kennan still wanted (do not overstate the dovishness)
- Whether the Marshall Plan named the Soviets, and what happened when they were invited

Events that hardened the divide

- Czechoslovakia coup (1948) · Yugoslav–Soviet split (1948) · Acheson on Tito
- Communist victory in China (1949) · Soviet atomic test (1949)
- Sino-Soviet alliance (1950) · Korean War (1950–1953)
- Communist electoral strength in Europe
- The monolith that was not — what US policymakers got wrong, and why it mattered

The order

- Three goals: check Soviet expansion, promote recovery, promote integration

Pillar	Institutions
Security	NATO, CENTO, SEATO, UN
Diplomacy and governance	UN; IAEA, WHO, UN Human Rights Council
Economic	Bretton Woods — GATT (WTO 1995), World Bank, IMF

- Ikenberry on self-constraint — why a hegemon binds itself
- FDR's Four Policemen — the road not taken
- Why the US insisted Europeans lead on NATO, and what the US feared paying
- Why economic openness was the lesson policymakers drew from the 1930s
- Foreign aid as an extension of the welfare state

- Ten changes to US foreign policy after 1945 — be able to produce most of the list
- Why Europeans accepted US leadership: military weakness, economic weakness, intra-European competition
- Why others did, and why others were wary — Wilson in 1919, and US racial practice

After the Cold War

- Unipolar moment — and the shift to peacekeeping, enforcement, stabilization, liberalization
- Gulf War: Kuwait invaded August 2, 1990; UN approval November 29; deadline January 15, 1991
- Why the US stopped at the border, and what followed for the Kurds and Shia
- Deng Xiaoping's reforms; GATT becomes the WTO (1995); China accedes (2001)
- Why Chinese WTO accession is called a defining transition of the era
- September 11, 2001; the War on Terror; Afghanistan (2001), Iraq (2003)
- Rogue states and the Axis of Evil; drones and cyberwarfare; targeted killing

6. The Cold War and Domestic Politics

Before the consensus

- Three core elements of Cold War policy: military power, free trade and investment, multilateral engagement
- Northeastern manufacturing and protection — and why protection correlates with conflict
- Electoral math: 214 of 224 electoral votes, 1900
- Shipbuilding, mining, smelting — the regional coalition

What changed

- Security: Pearl Harbor, Republicans in the cabinet, Stimson, the Soviet threat
- Divided government: the 80th Congress (1946); why blocking power produced cooperation
- The League as a cautionary tale about domestic politics
- Arthur Vandenberg — the conversion and its consequences
- Republican fingerprints on policy: "Operation Rathole," the ask requirement, NATO self-help provisions
- Low polarization; moderates; bipartisan appointments and when they surged
- Economics: Trubowitz on shifting global position
- Hiscox (1999) — the figure, and what happened to Republican competitors abroad
- Why Democratic positions fall in the 1970s–1980s and then rebound
- What this does to the story about Congress delegating trade authority

The geography of defense spending

- FDR siting bases in the South — and why bases are sticky
- Defense spending as a share of state GDP: Alabama, Mississippi, Virginia
- Spending spread across districts vs. personnel concentrated in a few
- What that distribution does to the politics of cutting defense

Civil rights as foreign policy

- James Byrnes — Secretary of State, 1945–1947, and segregationist

- What the State Department feared from the UN Commission on Human Rights
- Limiting petitions to member states — and the National Negro Congress petition, June 6, 1946
- Walter White, Thurgood Marshall, and Carol Anderson on the origins of "civil rights"

Collapse — or not

- The standard account: Vietnam, and the divergent lessons each party drew
- The standard account: 1989, and bipartisanship as a product of external threat
- Three problems with that account — including the comparative test it fails
- The economic alternative: Republicans to the South and West, Democrats to urban labor
- Why the same theory explains both the rise and the fall

Where things stand now

- Aberration or new normal? Zero-sum trade, tariffs as leverage, aggressive intervention
- The alternative path: a return to Bush-era unilateralism-with-engagement
- Connect this back to Section 2, first row.

7. Readings

For each: what is the argument, what is the evidence, and how does it connect to lecture?

Reading	Prompt
Declaration of Independence (1776)	Which grievances are foreign policy grievances?
Washington's Farewell Address (1796)	What exactly is being ruled out, and what is not?
J.Q. Adams, Independence Day Address (1821)	"Monsters to destroy" — what is the warning?
Anti-Federalist Papers: Brutus X	What is the danger, and what does it imply about post-1945 America?
Turner, "Significance of the Frontier" (1893)	What is the thesis, and why does the timing matter?
Wilson's Fourteen Points (1918)	Which points survive into the post-1945 order?
Norris, The Enduring Struggle (2021)	Why "uneasy"? Aid as charity, welfare state, or containment?
Dudziak, "Brown as a Cold War Case" (2004)	What is the international mechanism, and what does it imply about rights won strategically?
Fordham (2007), Cold War military spending	Which party favored high defense spending, and when did that change?
Kennan, "Sources of Soviet Conduct" (1947)	What kind of containment?
NSC-68 (1950)	What kind of containment — and what kind of state does it require?
The Truman Doctrine (1947)	How much broader is the commitment than the occasion?

8. People

Person	Associated with
George Washington	Farewell Address
Alexander Hamilton / Thomas Jefferson	The founding-era factional divide
Robert Livingston	Louisiana Purchase
James Monroe	Monroe Doctrine, 1823
Andrew Jackson	Nullification Crisis
John L. O'Sullivan	Manifest Destiny
Thomas Catesby	Monterey, 1842
Frederick Jackson Turner	The frontier thesis
Theodore Roosevelt	Roosevelt Corollary; arbitration
Woodrow Wilson	Fourteen Points; the League
Henry Cabot Lodge	The Irreconcilables
Elihu Root	Legalist internationalism
Henry L. Stimson	Republican internationalism; Secretary of War; the atomic decision
Franklin D. Roosevelt	Four Policemen; mobilization; Southern bases
Harry S. Truman	Truman Doctrine
George C. Marshall	Marshall Plan
George F. Kennan	Containment
Paul Nitze	NSC-68
Thomas Schelling	Deterrence theory
Arthur Vandenberg	Bipartisan consensus
James Byrnes	Civil rights and foreign policy
Walter White / Thurgood Marshall	NAACP and the UN
Dean Acheson	Tito; pragmatism
Saddam Hussein / George H.W. Bush	Gulf War
Deng Xiaoping	Chinese reform and WTO accession

9. Timeline

Date	Event
1783	Treaty of Paris
1796	Washington's Farewell Address

Date	Event
1803	Louisiana Purchase
1807 / 1808	British slave trade abolished / US bans international slave trade
1812–1815	War of 1812
1821	Mexican independence; Adams's Independence Day address
1823	Monroe Doctrine
1828 / 1832–33	Tariff of 1828; Nullification Crisis
1835–1836	Texas Revolution
1841 / 1842	Creole case / Capture of Monterey
1845	Texas annexed; "Manifest Destiny" coined
1846–1848	Mexican–American War
1861–1865	Civil War
1870s	US economy surpasses Britain
1893	Turner's frontier thesis
1898	Spanish–American War; Hawaii annexed
1917	US enters WWI; Russian Revolution
1918 / 1919	Fourteen Points / Versailles; League created; Senate rejects
1922 / 1930	Washington and London Naval Conferences
October 29, 1929	Stock market crash
1931 / 1933	Japan occupies Manchuria / Hitler to power
1935–1939	Neutrality Acts
1938	Austria (March); Sudetenland (September)
September 3, 1939	Germany invades Poland
1940 / March 1941	France falls; Destroyers for Bases / Lend-Lease
December 7–8, 1941	Pearl Harbor; the Philippines
1944	Percentages Agreement; Warsaw Uprising
April 12 / May 8, 1945	Roosevelt dies / Germany surrenders
August 6 / 9 / 14, 1945	Hiroshima; Nagasaki; Japanese surrender
1946	Long Telegram; Britain withdraws from Greece and Turkey; NNC petition; 80th Congress elected
March / June 1947	Truman Doctrine / Marshall's Harvard address; X Article
1948	Czechoslovakia coup; Yugoslav–Soviet split
1949	China; Soviet atomic test; NATO
1950	NSC-68; Sino-Soviet alliance; Korean War begins

Date	Event
1953 / 1954	Korean War ends / Brown v. Board
1989	Berlin Wall falls
1990–1991	Gulf War
1995 / 2001	WTO created / China accedes; September 11; Afghanistan
2003	Invasion of Iraq

10. Themes to Trace

Essay questions come from here. For each theme, collect three pieces of evidence from different points in the unit.

- Ideals vs. interests. Jefferson and executive power. Britain on slavery and the Confederacy. The US on UN human rights machinery.
- Domestic issues that are foreign policy issues. Slavery. Tariffs. Segregation.
- Coalitions follow economic position. Tariffs in 1828, expansion in 1898, trade and defense spending after 1945.
- Engagement without commitment. The Farewell Address, the interwar naval conferences, Republican objections to the League and to NATO.
- Technology shapes policy. Sail to steam. Monitors vs. blue water. Coaling stations to bases. MIRVs. Drones.
- Institutions bind their builders. Ikenberry on self-constraint — and the cases where the US declined to be bound.
- What counts as a cause. Sparks vs. escalation. Single-event explanations and why they fail.
- Individuals matter, sometimes. Lodge and Wilson. Vandenberg. Kennan and Nitze.
- Continuity and rupture. Which features of 1945 were genuinely new, and which had precedent.

11. Practice

Identifications — what, when, and why it matters

Mercantilism · Monroe Doctrine · Creole case · Ordinance of Nullification · Manifest Destiny · Roosevelt Corollary · Turner thesis · The Irreconcilables · Washington Naval Conference · Lend-Lease · Long Telegram · NSC-68 · Percentages Agreement · Marshall Plan · Bretton Woods · Deterrence · Security dilemma · 80th Congress · Arthur Vandenberg · Unipolar moment · Axis of Evil

Short answer

1. Why is "isolationism" an imprecise description of the Farewell Address? Of the interwar period?
2. How does the Monroe Doctrine support both sides of the 1898 debate?
3. Why was the atomic decision not only about Japan?
4. Kennan authored containment and opposed NATO. Reconcile.
5. Define deterrence. Why is credibility essential?
6. Why did divided government after 1946 produce cooperation rather than gridlock?
7. Trace the Neutrality Acts to Lend-Lease. What does the sequence show?
8. State Fordham's finding and his mechanism.
9. How does naval technology help explain overseas bases?

10. What does hegemony mean here, and what does it not mean?

Essay

1. Which periodization boundary matters most — 1870, 1945, or the one now underway? Defend the choice.
2. "US foreign policy has been shaped more by domestic economic interests than by external threats." Evaluate with evidence from at least two eras.
3. Did the Cold War consensus collapse because of Vietnam and 1989, or because interests evolved? Adjudicate.
4. Using Dudziak and the Byrnes material: was American racial practice a foreign policy problem before it was a domestic political one?
5. Kennan's containment vs. NSC-68. What did each assume, what did each require, and which describes what the US did?
6. Rules-based order alongside intervention, segregation, and the weakening of human rights machinery. Hypocrisy, strategy, or the ordinary condition of a hegemon?
7. Does commerce produce peace? Trace the belief from the early republic to Bretton Woods and assess it.
8. Is the current treatment of trade as zero-sum an aberration or a return? Use the full arc of the unit.

12. Common Pitfalls

- Calling any period "isolationist."
- Treating containment as one policy.
- Treating standing armies, alliances, and high defense spending as American traditions.
- Treating slavery and civil rights as interruptions of the foreign policy story.
- Attributing party positions to fixed ideology.
- Saying World War II ended the Depression.
- Explaining a war by its spark.
- Treating the communist bloc as monolithic.
- Giving a date without a significance.